

SFPA Spring 2026 City Championship

Title Odds — Tournament Projection

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Rawhides are the favorite to win the City Championship at **65%**, ahead of a tight chase between **Hall Monitors** (15%) and **Bus Stop** (14%). Together the top three hold about 93% of all title equity; below them the field falls off sharply.

Team	Seed	Title %	Reach Grand Final
Happy Lounge Rawhides	1	64.8%	79%
Hall Monitors	4	14.6%	34%
Bus Stop Flyers	3	13.7%	45%
Pocket Full of Fizz	7	2.4%	15%
Pilsner InnDecisives	6	1.9%	10%
El Farolito Shooters	2	1.7%	9%
Marcelo's Hall Stars	8	0.9%	8%
Happy HALLers	5	0.0%	0%
Gino & Carlo	9	0.0%	0%
Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	10	0.0%	0%
Friends Crooked Cues	11	0.0%	0%
Route 101 Dalmatians	12	0.0%	0%
Karl's Freakin' Beacon	13	0.0%	0%
Temple Holy Smokes	14	0.0%	0%
Bus Slop	15	0.0%	0%
Lower Haight Misfits	16	0.0%	0%

Last Week: Winners' Bracket R2 (QF) + Losers' Bracket R1

Start with the favorite, because the favorite just tightened its grip. A week ago the model gave Rawhides 48.5% to win the City Championship; tonight that number leapt to 64.8% — a 16.3-point jump and the biggest one-week swing of the playoffs so far. A race that looked genuinely open at the draw suddenly has a clear front-runner and a lot of daylight behind it.

The reason has almost nothing to do with Rawhides themselves and everything to do with the carnage behind them. In a single night the two best teams in the field not named Rawhides were both dumped into the losers' bracket: El Farolito, the 2nd seed, fell to Pocket Fizz 9-4, and Pilsner, the 6th seed, went down to Bus Stop 9-7. Coming in, the pair were essentially tied for the second-best title odds in the tournament — and they lost on the same evening.

Neither was supposed to happen. El Farolito were 74.7% favorites over Pocket Fizz; Pilsner were 60.4% favorites over Bus Stop. El Farolito in particular ran into a decidedly beatable opponent and still couldn't close it out — a roughly 3-in-4 favorite going home. Stack the two together and the model gave that double knockout about a 10% chance — call it a 1-in-10 night. It happened anyway, and every team still on the winners' side got more valuable overnight, Rawhides most of all.

Rawhides wasn't the only team to cash in on the upheaval. Bus Stop, who put Pilsner out, jumped from 4.9% to 13.7% and into a winners'-bracket semifinal; Hall Monitors climbed to 14.6% (from 12.7%) — the equity the fallen contenders left behind had to go somewhere, and the teams still standing on the A-side collected it.

Don't count the fallen out — this is double elimination. El Farolito still carry the 4th-highest team rating in the field (1605), and Pilsner still carry the 2nd-highest team rating in the field (1632). With Evan Burgess back in the lineup, Pilsner on paper are the second-strongest side in the whole draw. But the longer road shows up in the numbers — El Farolito slid from 14.5% to 1.7% and Pilsner slid from 14.1% to 1.9% — and each now sits one loss from elimination.

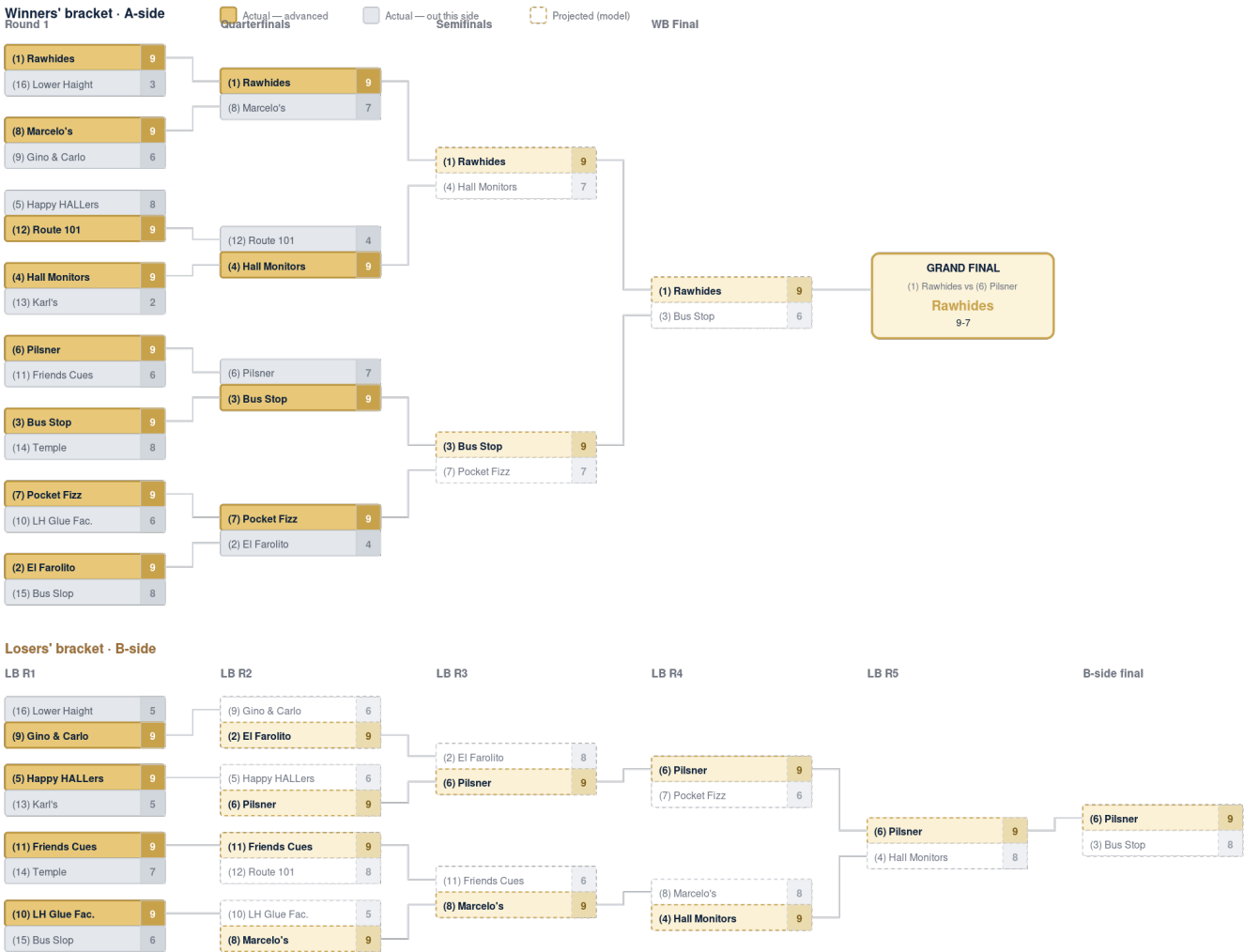
The night also claimed its first casualties: Karl's, Temple, Bus Slop, and Lower Haight all lost for the second time and are out. The winners'-bracket survivors roll on with a cushion; everyone else is now one loss from the exit.

Result	Model predicted	Actual
(1) Rawhides def. (8) Marcelo's	Rawhides 9-6	9-7
(4) Hall Monitors def. (12) Route 101	Hall Monitors 9-5	9-4
(3) Bus Stop def. (6) Pilsner — beat the pick	Pilsner 9-8	9-7
(7) Pocket Fizz def. (2) El Farolito — UPSET	El Farolito 9-6	9-4
(9) Gino & Carlo def. (16) Lower Haight	Gino & Carlo 9-5	9-5
(5) Happy HALLers def. (13) Karl's	Happy HALLers 9-5	9-5
(11) Friends Cues def. (14) Temple — beat the pick	Temple 9-8	9-7
(10) LH Glue Factory def. (15) Bus Slop	LH Glue Factory 9-8	9-6

Model-predicted score (favorite and expected margin) vs. the actual result. Shaded rows mark a match the model's pick lost; winner's game count shown first.

Projected Bracket

Single most-likely path through the 16-team double elimination. Lose on the A-side (winners') and you drop to the B-side (losers"); a second loss ends your run. The B-side survivor must beat the A-side finalist twice. **Grand Final:** (1) Rawhides vs (6) Pilsner — champion **Rawhides** (9-7).



The Storylines

Pilsner: 15-0 in the playoffs against everyone but Rawhides

The most remarkable number in this field belongs to a 6-seed. Over the last four City Championships, **Pilsner InnDecisives have gone 17-7 in playoff matches**, and every one of their losses came against a single team: the Happy Lounge Rawhides. Against the other fifteen playoff opponents they've faced, Pilsner is a perfect **15-0**, reaching the final four years running. That is why a sixth seed is the model's #2 title pick at 2% — the regular season undersells them.

The Burgess effect: why Pilsner slipped to the 6-seed

So why isn't Pilsner seeded higher? Their best player, **Evan Burgess (576 Fargo)**, **didn't play until Week 7**, missing the first half of the season. Pilsner won 57% of their games without him and 61% with him — enough of an early dip to drop them several seed lines, landing them sixth. He's back now and the lineup is whole, but the seeding is locked, and that one fact ripples through the entire bracket.

One half of the bracket is a war; the other is a stroll

The 6-seed lands Pilsner in the bottom half, alongside El Farolito (2) and Bus Stop (3) — three of the four strongest non-Rawhides teams stacked together, forced to eliminate each other just to reach the final. Rawhides' top half is far softer. It shows in their odds: **Rawhides reach the grand final 79%** of the time, while **El Farolito and Pilsner sit near 9%** — not because they're weak, but because their path is brutal.

Rawhides: so good on paper it barely matters that they've cooled off

By season form, Rawhides actually graded out slightly negative (-10) — they won a touch less than even their own loaded lineup predicted. Yet they're still the runaway #1 at 65%, because their Fargo (609) and Team Elo (1702) tower over the field by enough that a small slump doesn't move them. But favorite isn't lock: these are races to 9, and Pilsner has taken them to the brink repeatedly — Rawhides lead their nine playoff meetings 7-2, but two went Pilsner's way.

El Farolito: the team playing above its paper

El Farolito posted the best season form in the field (+28) — consistently winning more than their roster's raw Fargo predicted, the signature of a team peaking at the right time. The model rewards it, lifting them into a co-#2 tie at 2%. The catch is the draw: stuck in the loaded bottom half, even a hot team faces Pilsner and Bus Stop before any shot at Rawhides.

Team Elo — Overall Strength

Each team's strength rating: the Fargo of their best playoff lineup, adjusted for season form, plus a data-tested pedigree where earned. Higher = stronger. This is what drives the title odds.

Rank	Team	Team Elo	Top-4 Fargo	Title %
1	Happy Lounge Rawhides	1702	609.5	64.8%
2	Pilsner InnDecisives	1632	539.0	1.9%
3	Hall Monitors	1620	567.0	14.6%
4	El Farolito Shooters	1605	548.0	1.7%
5	Marcelo's Hall Stars	1598	553.8	0.9%
6	Bus Stop Flyers	1594	550.5	13.7%
7	Pocket Full of Fizz	1526	515.0	2.4%
8	Happy HALLers	1509	503.8	0.0%
9	Temple Holy Smokes	1508	513.2	0.0%
10	Gino & Carlo	1502	505.2	0.0%
11	Friends Crooked Cues	1454	478.0	0.0%
12	Route 101 Dalmatians	1412	455.8	0.0%
13	Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	1401	453.8	0.0%
14	Bus Slop	1378	443.2	0.0%
15	Karl's Freakin' Beacon	1363	431.8	0.0%
16	Lower Haight Misfits	1317	409.8	0.0%

How These Numbers Were Built

1. A rating based on who actually plays. Each team is rated by its players' Fargo (skill) ratings — but performance is judged against the lineup it *actually fielded* each match, not its best-case roster. If a team rests a star or plays a weaker substitute who performs at their own level, the model doesn't punish them: it expected less, and got it. When a 405-rated depth player loses most of his games to 600-rated opponents, that's neutral, not a black mark. Most rating systems can't tell "played badly" from "fielded a weaker lineup" — this one can, because it reads every individual player's result in every match.

2. Win probabilities — and proof they work. Playoff matches are a race to 9 (a 9-3 match ends after 12 games). The Fargo gap between the two lineups sets each game's odds, capped at 75/25 since pool has too much variance for locks; at 8-8 a single deciding game is played between each team's top player. We back-tested the engine on this season: it correctly called **76.5% of 251 matches** (Brier score 0.154), with well-calibrated confidence — the basis for trusting the odds.

3. 60,000 simulated tournaments. The full double-elimination bracket is played 60,000 times; every number in this report — the title odds and the projected bracket — comes from that one simulation, so they're mutually consistent.

4. A data-tested pedigree for Pilsner. Rather than guess at a "dynasty" weight, we tested it: across four seasons of playoff results, Pilsner's record is 4-season playoff record 17-7 (71%), and every loss came against Rawhides — against everyone else they are a perfect 15-0. That overperformance is statistically real ($p < 0.05$), so Pilsner carries a measured +30 Fargo playoff bump. No other team earned one; Rawhides' four titles are the best team doing what it should, already in its rating.

Every adjustment has a number behind it, not a feel. Pool is high-variance — treat these as probabilities, not predictions; even a clear favorite loses far more often than it wins.

Appendix — Season Form

A supporting metric, not a strength rating: did a team beat or miss its own roster's Fargo expectation this season, match by match? A strong team can show negative form if it underplayed its talent.

Team	Season Form	vs roster
El Farolito Shooters	+28.0	overachieved
Happy HALLers	+17.2	overachieved
Route 101 Dalmatians	+14.4	overachieved
Karl's Freakin' Beacon	+13.9	overachieved
Friends Crooked Cues	+11.6	overachieved
Lower Haight Misfits	+10.8	overachieved
Pocket Full of Fizz	+8.1	overachieved
Pilsner InnDecisives	+4.9	~ as expected
Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	+4.0	~ as expected
Bus Stop Flyers	+3.5	~ as expected
Gino & Carlo	+2.4	~ as expected
Bus Slop	+1.6	~ as expected
Marcelo's Hall Stars	+0.1	~ as expected
Hall Monitors	-7.3	underachieved
Happy Lounge Rawhides	-10.4	underachieved

Team	Season Form	vs roster
Temple Holy Smokes	-13.5	underachieved